

AsteriskNOW gives you reports of system information such as CPU loads, network interface information, system logs, and even a text console for executing direct commands to Asterisk. It's claimed that a machine with a 3 GHz processor and 1 GB of RAM will be able to sustain up to 15 simultaneous connections. You can monitor all active connections using the Web interface, and back up and restore all your settings and data as needed.

You obviously will need some hardware to act as an interface for the telephone lines for

Asterisk to function. Digium is a company that uses and works closely with Asterisk as software to run their hardware. Digium hardware can be found through a couple of distributors in India, too. Visit <http://asterisk.pbx.in> for more. The software works fine with other manufacturers as well, though. They make PCI cards that allow many phone lines to be connected to a computer.

It is clear that AsteriskNOW isn't meant for home users, but for a SoHo setup, it's a very cheap solution.

Education

It's pretty hard to put "Linux" and "education" in a single sentence. This category is for school-going children who can use Linux in their daily academic life and also as a regular operating system in their free time.

Edubuntu 7.0.4

Site: www.edubuntu.org

Size: 695 MB

Edubuntu, like Ubuntu Studio, is based on Ubuntu and is targeted at the young ones. Unlike Ubuntu Studio, this distribution comes as a Live CD, and has a GUI for its installer as well.

Edubuntu isn't just for schoolkids—there are quite a few applications meant for very young children as well. Tux Paint, for example, is a drawing application for children, much like MS Paint. The interface is stacked with large, colourful icons. Another educational game that should be fun for kids is called GCompris, a collection of many simple math games and puzzles. There are also some simple games and quizzes that ask the user to find colours, as well as some reading games. They're all meant to teach kids real stuff while keeping it fun.

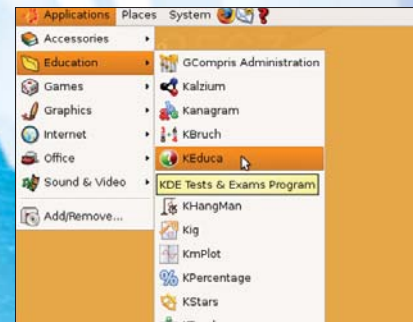
For the slightly grown-up, there's an application called KTurtle, a KDE clone of the old programming language called Logo, where you use text commands to draw. There are some maths programs as well.

KEduca by itself is a program that allows students to take tests, and marks are given accordingly. KEducaBuilder is a program that

accompanies it, and lets you design tests that can be run on KEduca—really useful for teachers and parents alike. Kalzium is a program that shows the periodic table of elements and a lot more information like chemical data, history details, and more. It even shows photos for quite a few of the elements, which makes it more interactive and interesting.

Edubuntu doesn't throw out the standard software package, though—you get the OpenOffice suite, some media players, instant messengers, Firefox, and Evolution for your mail. You can also add and remove programs with simplicity similar to that of Ubuntu.

This operating system meant for kids could have been designed to be a lot more colourful and interactive to make it even more appealing—something like the software in it, like GCompris. They also could have given the user a choice of choosing between a couple of different layouts and schemes, each suited for a different age group. All in all, it's an operating system with lots of fun things to do, with bits of educational value added.



Learning and fun together on a Linux distribution. But make sure they learn



The Indian Flavour

A few enterprising Indian groups have decided to make Linux easily accessible to non-English speaking public by creating distributions for them.

IndLinux—Rangoli 1.0b

Site: <http://www.indlinux.org/>

Size: 688 MB

IndLinux is one of the more prominent Linux distributions we came across, and we had to look at it. It's a Live CD based on Morphix, which in turn is a derivative of Debian.

When you first boot from the CD, you can choose from seven languages. You can also choose to use KDE or GNOME if you select Hindi. The other languages boot up into the GNOME desktop environment.

Not all menus and programs are translated into the regional languages, though, and this differs from language to language. You can switch between languages for

